

Nicholas Clarke, PhD

Independent Researcher — AI Alignment, Evaluation & Governance

Cambridge, UK

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RESEARCH FOCUS

AI alignment with a focus on alignment target specification, evaluation under optimisation, and value robustness. Work includes modelling idealised human preferences, analysing proxy failure and Goodhart effects, and developing conceptual frameworks that connect alignment targets to evaluation and governance of advanced AI systems.

EDUCATION

PhD in Philosophy — University of London

Awarded with no corrections (rare distinction)

Thesis: *Goal Theory* — a naturalistic account of idealised human desire

MA in Philosophy (Distinction) — University of London

Dissertation applying Bayesian reasoning to complex evidential claims under uncertainty

RESEARCH OUTPUTS (SELECTED)

- *Beyond Behavioural Control: Idealised Human Desire as an Alignment Target in AI* — submitted to *Minds and Machines*
 - A programme of academic work developing *Goal Theory*, a naturalistic framework for morality, with applications to moral disagreement, moral luck, non-identity, and metaethical semantics
 - Independent work in epistemology and the theory of reasons, developing non-factive operational accounts of reasons and knowledge suited to deliberation under epistemic uncertainty
 - Working papers on empirical preference modelling, alignment target robustness, and human-in-the-loop idealisation
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ACADEMIC & TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Associate Lecturer — AI Ethics & Technology

Anglia Ruskin University

Research-informed teaching on AI risk, alignment challenges, and governance

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE (COMPRESSED)

University of Cambridge — Reporting & Information Analyst

Empirical analysis, structured evaluation, and decision-focused reporting across large organisational datasets.

Prior roles in technical research, documentation, analytics, and software development, including senior positions in enterprise systems and SaaS environments.

METHODS & SKILLS

Research design • conceptual analysis • evidence synthesis • experimental design • human-in-the-loop studies • quantitative analysis • systems thinking • failure-mode analysis • research communication • interdisciplinary collaboration

PUBLIC WRITING

Essays on AI alignment, ethics, and moral theory (Substack).